The Landscape

Every menu in your stack as of 16 October 2026: Perplexity's picker, the OpenRouter catalog, and agents you can run on your own PC. Web research only; nothing on your PC was opened or changed. Prepared for Tyler Herigstad by **Claude Opus 5.5** (model ID claude-opus-5-5), **thinking at Max**. A menu is not a receipt: nothing here was run against a fixture. Under your 7 September rule, four models from other families reviewed it on 21 October: ChatGPT, Gemini 4 Argon, Kimi K3 and Grok 4.7 Expert. It was corrected after their review. Numbers in grey brackets point to the numbered sources at the end.

The map on one page

- **One question, up to eight models at once.** Perplexity's Model Council runs one question across several models and shows where they agree and where they disagree: three you choose on the web and in the iPhone app, for Max, or two to eight inside Computer, on any paid plan. [1, 36] OpenRouter's Fusion does the same with models you pick from its catalog, and one tester ran about ten comparisons for roughly 40 cents. [21] For the Ledger, only each model's own answer is a receipt. The merged summary is the tool's writing, not a model's return.
- **Your Perplexity picker moved under you.** Since a published 4 September snapshot: Gemini 3.8 Flash replaced 3.7 Flash, Claude Sonnet 5.5 replaced Sonnet 5, and GPT-5.6 Terra gave way to GPT-6 Sol and then GPT-6.1 Sol. Grok 4.7 was swapped out for Claude Haiku 5.5 on 8 October and swapped back the next day. [3, 4, 5, 6, 35] Kimi K3, GLM 5.3 and Nemotron 3 Ultra, three of the models you already have receipts for through Perplexity, were all on the menu. [3, 8, 9, 38]
- **OpenRouter is the widest menu in your stack:** 500+ models from 94 providers on one account. The free tier offers 25+ models at 50 requests a day. [13, 14] Most of its most-used models have no receipts in your stack: DeepSeek V4.1 Flash, Step 5 Preview, GLM 5.3 Flash, MiMo-V2.6-Flash and Hy4 preview. [16]
- **Hermes Agent is the most-used app on OpenRouter**, at 1.68 trillion tokens, ahead of Claude Code at 1.26 trillion. [16] It is installed on your PC and unused. Before its first run it needs five safety settings, and it must never be pointed at SecondSignal. [24, 25]
- **The Llama slot has moved.** In April 2026 Meta turned from open Llama models to Muse Spark, a closed model. [28] Its open-weight models now are Muse Glimmer (30B, released 10 August, built to run on one machine) [29] and Muse Spark Open, listed on OpenRouter on 15 October. [15]
- **Gemini 4 Argon**, already in your Round One fixtures, began rolling out on 13 October to Google AI Pro and Ultra subscribers. [30] It is also on OpenRouter at half price in batch mode. [15]
- **Skip OpenClaw for now.** It went viral, and it has a record: a hijacking flaw rated 8.8 out of 10, more than 21,000 copies exposed online before the patch, and malware found among its add-on skills. [26]

1. Perplexity's menu

Perplexity's own help page on models [40] redirected to its help-center front page on 16 October, so the menu below is rebuilt from a dated, published snapshot plus dated change trackers. Your screen is the record: one screenshot of your picker settles it.

The Search picker on 4 September (published snapshot)

- **Pro:** Sonar 2, GPT-5.6 Terra, Claude Sonnet 5, Gemini 3.7 Flash, Grok 4.6, Kimi K3, GLM 5.3 and Nemotron 3 Ultra. [3]
- **Max:** the same eight, plus GPT-5.6 Sol and Claude Opus 5. [3]
- **Best** is the automatic choice. Free users get Best only; picking a model by hand takes Pro or Max. Deep Research picks its own models, so the picker does not control it. [3]

Swaps since then

- **5 September:** Gemini 3.7 Flash became Gemini 3.8 Flash on Perplexity's plan page. [4]

- **23 September:** GPT-5.6 Terra was swapped for GPT-6 Sol in multi-model answers. [4]
- **29 September:** Claude Sonnet 5 became Claude Sonnet 5.5 in the Pro lineup. [4]
- **30 September:** GPT-6 Sol became GPT-6.1 Sol in the Computer and Pro lineup. [5]
- **8 October:** Grok 4.7 was removed from Computer's lineup and Claude Haiku 5.5 added. The tracker does not say whether Grok also left the regular picker. [6]
- **9 October:** the swap was reversed: Grok 4.7 came back and Claude Haiku 5.5 left the Pro lineup. [35]
- **Computer also carries** GLM 5.3 (from 28 August) [7] and Claude Fable 5.1 (from 1 September, Pro and Max). [39]

Modes worth knowing

- **Model Council.** It launched on 5 February 2026 for Max, running three models and a synthesis of their answers. [2] Since late July, inside Computer, you choose two to eight models from OpenAI, Google, Anthropic and open providers, and its synthesis shows where the models agree, where they disagree, and what each one surfaced alone. [1] On the web and in the iPhone app it runs three models you choose, for Max; inside Computer it is open to every paid plan. [36] Using it for fixtures would change your Perplexity card's rule of plain Search mode only, so that is your call, and every model's own answer would be saved as its own return file. [33]
- **Computer** is Perplexity's agent mode, open to Pro since March 2026, with "over 20" models behind it; Max adds monthly credits for it. [10]
- **Perplexity's own models.** Sonar 2 is the picker's label for Perplexity's own model. [3] On 6 October Perplexity also released pplx-decider-v1.1-27b, an open model that answers with a decision (yes or no, a choice, a score) instead of text. [11] That is the same kind of sensor your 8 October record describes for Jev. [34]

2. The OpenRouter catalog

What it is and what it costs

- One account and one key for 500+ models from 94 providers. [13, 14]
- **Free tier:** 25+ free models at 50 requests a day. [14] Buying $10 of credit once lifts free-model use to 1,000 requests a day for good, and free models are capped at 20 requests a minute. [20]
- **Pay as you go:** a 5.5% platform fee on credit you buy, at least $0.80 on a card purchase. [14, 20] Sample prices per million tokens, in then out: Nemotron 3 Ultra $0.50 and $2.20, with a free version too [18, 37]; Gemini 4 Argon in batch $1 and $5; Muse Spark Open $1.25 and $4.25; Nemotron 3.5 Super VL $0.10 and $0.40. [15]
- **My estimate, not a quote:** at a few thousand words each way, one fixture run costs cents on most models. The one measured figure found: about 40 cents for roughly ten multi-model comparisons. [21]

Running one fixture across many models

- The Chatroom is built to "compare LLMs on a single prompt". [17] Fusion, in OpenRouter's Labs, sends one prompt to the models you pick, shows each answer, then writes a fused one. [21]
- The door is OpenRouter's, not the model maker's app, so the file name records it, in the same shape as your Perplexity rule: RETURN_<fixture>_OPENROUTER_<model>.txt. [33]

What the leaderboard shows

- **Top ten by tokens** as captured on 16 October (the page offers day, week and month views, and the capture doesn't record which one it showed): DeepSeek V4.1 Flash (37.1 trillion), Step 5 Preview, GLM 5.3 Flash, MiMo-V2.6-Flash, Hy4 preview, Nemotron 3 Ultra (free), GPT-6 Luna, Claude Opus 5.5, GLM 5.3, and DeepSeek V4 Flash 0731. [16]
- **Top apps:** Hermes Agent (1.68 trillion tokens), Claude Code (1.26 trillion), Kilo Code (848 billion). [16]

- **Benchmark board** (Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index, shown on the same page): Claude Opus 5.5 57.6, Claude Sonnet 5.5 56.0, Claude Fable 5.1 53.4, Qwen3.8 Max 53.4, GPT-6 Astra 52.7, Gemini 4 Argon 52.6, GPT-6.1 Sol 51.8. [16] I am Claude, so weigh my reporting of a board that Claude tops accordingly. Popularity and benchmarks are someone else's test, not your receipts.

Privacy, before the first run

- OpenRouter's privacy settings can stop routing to providers that may train on your data, with separate settings for paid and free models. [19] Both get switched off before anything is sent.
- Some free and "stealth" models are paid for with your traffic: the provider of one stealth model, Owl Alpha, may log prompts and replies to improve its model. [20]
- The rule I'd propose: nothing from SecondSignal or your personal life goes to a free or stealth model, and, as always, a sealed answer key never goes into any model.

3. Agents you can run on your own PC

Hermes Agent (Nous Research): installed, unused

- **What it is:** open source (MIT licence) from Nous Research, released in February 2026. [22] It keeps one memory across restarts and across the apps you reach it from (Telegram, Slack, Discord, WhatsApp, email, the terminal), saves solved problems as reusable skills, runs scheduled jobs set up in plain English, and splits big jobs across subagents. [22, 23]
- **What it costs:** the software is free. Models are paid through a Nous Portal plan (pay-as-you-go from $10, or $20, $100 or $200 a month with $22, $110 or $220 of usage credit, as of June 2026) or with your own provider key, such as OpenRouter. [23]
- **Windows:** Nous's documentation has guides for Windows (Native), Windows (WSL2) and a Hermes Desktop app. [24]
- **The risk, from its own documentation:** by default ("smart" approvals) a helper model approves low-risk commands for you, so you do not see every dangerous one. The file guards cover only its file-writing tools, and its terminal runs as you, so it can reach any folder you can, SecondSignal included. [24, 25]
- **Five settings before its first run**, all from Nous's own security guides: commands run inside a container instead of on your PC (terminal.backend docker). Inside a container Hermes skips its ask-first checks, because the container is the wall, so a never-run list of commands is set too, and it holds even there (approvals.deny). Anything flagged outside a container asks you first, and an unanswered prompt is denied after five minutes (approvals.mode manual). Its file tools can write only to one working folder plus Hermes's own home (HERMES_WRITE_SAFE_ROOT), and its starting folder is that working folder, never SecondSignal (terminal.cwd). [24, 25] When you want it running, the setup is done for you, by me or Codex, and you press go.
- **What it could do later:** run one fixture across many OpenRouter models and save each return under your file-name rule, with no copying and no edits. That is an idea for the Workflow Blueprint, not a plan.

OpenClaw: skip for now

- An always-on agent with access to files, email, calendar and the command line, launched in late 2025. [26]
- Its record: a flaw rated 8.8 (CVE-2026-25253) that let a malicious website steal its login token and run code, patched in version 2026.1.29; more than 21,000 copies exposed online before the patch; an add-on skill classed as malware by Cisco; and the first known theft of a whole OpenClaw settings file, with every connected key in it. [26]

Local models: no account, no provider, no bill

- Ollama runs downloaded models on Windows, Mac and Linux. [27]

- Open models you can download include Meta's Muse Glimmer, a 30B model Meta says "can run locally" [29], and others such as OpenAI's gpt-oss-20b and Google's Gemma 4, which also appear on OpenRouter's free list. [20]
- Whether any of them fits your PC depends on your graphics card's memory, which this pass did not look at.
- Why bother: a local model is the cleanest door. Nothing you send leaves your PC, though Ollama keeps its own logs on it. [41] A local copy may also run weaker than the hosted one, so run it against the same model through OpenRouter and the gap becomes data.

4. What I'd run next, by your record

Grounded in the track record where a model family has one, and in the menus where it doesn't. Best first, then a generous list.

Five first receipts

1. **Qwen3.8 Max.** Qwen's record is split: two real code finds in round 3B, and more F's than A's. [38] Its Max version ties for third on the benchmark board above. [16] A sealed answer key settles which Qwen you are dealing with. Run it through Qwen's own site if it is offered there, since that is the door you already use.
2. **DeepSeek V4.1 Flash**, the most-used model on OpenRouter. [16] DeepSeek's record has useful Spanish fixtures and two "ALL TASKS COMPLETE" claims with tasks missing. [38] The fixture tests whether the new version still claims more than it did.
3. **GLM 5.3 Flash**, the cheap sibling of your best dissenter, at $0.15 in and $0.50 out through Perplexity's API. [12, 32] That API is in private preview, so access has to be requested first. [32] Does the dissent survive the discount?
4. **Muse Spark Open** (Meta, on OpenRouter since 15 October). [15] It fills the Llama slot in your stack with Meta's current line.
5. **Gemini 4 Argon** through OpenRouter, as a second run beside its Round One run. [15] If the Round One run went through the Gemini app, this becomes your first same-model, two-door test on a sealed key.

Extras worth a fixture

- **Step 5 Preview** (StepFun), **MiMo-V2.6-Flash** (Xiaomi) and **Hy4 preview** (Tencent): top five by tokens on OpenRouter, with no record anywhere in your stack. [16]
- **GPT-6 Luna**, the cheapest GPT-6 on Perplexity's API list ($0.10 in, $0.50 out), and seventh by tokens on OpenRouter. [12, 16]
- **Nemotron 3.5 Super VL** (NVIDIA, 15 October, reads images, with a free version). [15] Nemotron's trajectory turn led Claude to a real miss, even when its research failed. [38]
- **Kimi K3 through OpenRouter**: a third door for your most consistent reviewer, after kimi.com and Perplexity.
- **GLM 5.3 through OpenRouter**: the door test that matters most. chat.z.ai cut or failed every packet; does the API door fix that?
- **Claude Sonnet 5.5**, now on Perplexity. [4] Claude Haiku 5.5 was added on 8 October and taken off the next day. [6, 35] Any Claude return is graded by another model family.
- **Jev** (on OpenRouter's rankings as typesafe/jev-1.13) [16] and **pplx-decider** [11]: only as sensors, never as voices, as your 8 October record says. [34]

What this can't tell you

- Menus are not receipts. Nothing here was run against a fixture. Token counts measure popularity, and benchmark scores are someone else's test.
- The Perplexity picker is rebuilt from a 4 September snapshot plus dated change trackers, not read off your screen. Pro and Max differ, and I don't know which plan you are on.

- Prices change and sources disagree. Two sources give different OpenRouter prices for Kimi K3 ($0.294 and $24 per million tokens on one; $3 and $15 on the other), so no Kimi price is used here, and every price is a snapshot. [31]
- Several facts come from trade trackers and blogs rather than the companies themselves. Each is numbered so a reviewer can check it.
- Out of scope: Gemini Notebook, and anything that needs your PC: your graphics card, what is installed, and Hermes Agent's current settings.
- I am Claude. Claude models top the benchmark board quoted here and appear among the extras. In the outside review, ChatGPT and Gemini 4 Argon checked the board's numbers against the page, and they match.

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